

Elect according to the Foreknowledge of God

The subject of divine election has been a cause for much controversy and misunderstanding for many years. However, it is a truth most precious to be appreciated and enjoyed by every redeemed child of God, when understood in its proper context in relation to those passages of Scripture where it is referred to.

Election involves the sovereignty of God and the responsibility of man and is based on the foreknowledge of God. Foreknowledge, or knowing things before hand, can only be ascribed to the divine persons of the Godhead. God is omniscient, or all knowing.

The sacred Scriptures bear out the truth of God's omniscience. The psalmist wrote, *"great is our Lord, and of great power: his understanding is infinite"* (Ps. 147:5). Another psalm says, *"there is not a word in my tongue, but lo, O lord, thou knowest it altogether"* (Ps. 139:4). The Lord spoke in the prophecy of Isaiah, *"Remember the former things of old: for I am God, and there is none else; I am God, and there is none like me, Declaring the end from the beginning, and from ancient times the things that are not yet done, saying, My counsel shall stand, and I will do all my pleasure"* (Isa. 46:9-10).

Because He is God, knowing things before hand is also attributed to the Lord Jesus. Concerning that occasion in the Garden of Gethsemane, when men came to take the Lord Jesus, John wrote, *"Jesus therefore, knowing all things that should come upon him, went forth"* (Jn. 18:4). Peter acknowledged, *"Lord, thou knowest all things"* (Jn. 21:17).

God, in His infinite wisdom concluded that all men are in unbelief, in order that He might extend mercy to all of mankind. The apostle Paul praised God for such wisdom. He wrote, *"O the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and knowledge of God! how unsearchable are his judgments, and his ways past finding out!"* (Rom. 11:32-33).

Even though God has extended His mercy and grace to all of mankind, there is a responsibility for every individual to respond to Him. God's mercy and grace, in the form of the forgiveness of sins, is offered to all through the sacrificial death of the Lord Jesus and His precious blood, shed at Calvary's cross. Paul stressed the fact that God's salvation is for all. He wrote this of God our Saviour, *"Who will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth. For there is one God, and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus; Who gave himself a ransom for all"* (1st Tim. 2:5-6).

The Scriptures are very clear on the fact that repentance and faith toward God are necessary, and the responsibility of every individual in order to receive the salvation that God has offered through the Lord Jesus Christ. The apostle Paul declared to the elders of Ephesus how he had spent his life spreading the message of the gospel and the responsibility of all man kind to respond in faith to God 's offer of grace. He described his ministry as, *"Testifying both to the Jews and also to the Greeks, repentance toward God, and of faith toward our Lord Jesus Christ"* (Acts 20:21).

In writing to Timothy, Paul wrote of God's desire for all to respond to Him in faith, *"Who will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth"* (1st Tim. 2:4). One of the most well-known verses of the Bible points out the need for individual response to God's offer of salvation through the Lord Jesus Christ, *"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life"* (Jn. 3:16).

The word, “*elect*”, means, “*chosen*”, and reminds us of God’s divine purposes and plans in salvation. It is interesting to learn that the first mention of the word, “*elect*”, is in reference to the Lord Jesus Christ. The prophet Isaiah wrote, “*Behold my servant, whom I uphold; mine elect, in whom my soul delighteth; I have put my spirit upon him: he shall bring forth judgment to the Gentiles*” (Isa. 42:1). The Lord Jesus Christ is God’s chosen one.

The rulers of Israel understood that Christ, the Messiah was the chosen of God. They did not believe that the Lord Jesus was the chosen Messiah. Luke, the gospel writer recorded how the rulers of Israel derided the Lord Jesus, while He was on the cross, “*And the rulers also with them derided him, saying, He saved others; let him save himself, if he be Christ, the chosen of God*” (Luke 23:35). Peter describes the Lord Jesus as the living stone rejected by men but chosen of God, “*To whom coming, as unto a living stone, disallowed indeed of men, but chosen of God, and precious*” (1st Pet. 2:4).

The blessed truth of election, is that God in His divine wisdom and matchless grace, has chosen those of us who have been redeemed by precious blood before the foundation of the world (Eph. 1:4). In fact, God devised the plan of salvation through the blood of the Lamb, before He laid the foundation of the world (Rev. 13:8).

The word, “*chosen*”, is also associated with God’s purchase and God’s possession. Moses reminded the people of Israel of the fact that they had been chosen by God as His purchased possession; “*The Lord hath chosen thee to be a peculiar people unto himself, above all the nations that are upon the earth*” (Deut. 14:2).

Peter used similar language in describing believers today; “*but ye are a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, an holy nation, a peculiar people*” (1st Pet. 2:9). The word, “*peculiar*”, can be translated as “*purchased possession*”.

We are not only a chosen purchased possession; we are also chosen for a purpose. What the Lord said of the apostle Paul, “*He is a chosen vessel unto me, to bear my name*” (Acts 9:15), is true of all who by faith accept the Lord Jesus Christ as Saviour. We who belong to the Lord Jesus Christ have the privilege, as well as the responsibility, of bearing His name.

In addition, believers are chosen and preserved. Peter reminds us that we are kept by the power of God until the moment when we will be saved from the very presence of sin and raptured home to be with the Lord Jesus (1st Pet. 1:3-5). Paul wrote that the Lord would preserve him unto His heavenly kingdom (2nd Tim. 4:18).

Time and space to do allow us to consider all the verses of Scripture that tell us believers are chosen by God according to His purposes in grace. But I do want to close out with the thought that believers are chosen and precious. The Lord said through the prophet Isaiah, “*since thou wast precious in my sight, thou hast been honourable and I have loved thee*” (Isa. 43:4).

John recorded of the Lord Jesus, “*having loved his own which were in the world, he loved them unto the end*” (Jn. 13:1).

*God’s purpose in election,
He has made clearly known,
Objects of His affection
Could now become His own.*

*The plan of great salvation,
In ages past was planned;
Before the earth's foundation,
Before the skies were spanned.*

*God's full and free redemption,
For all of Adam's race;
There would be no exemption
From His free gift of grace.*

*Pardon for sin was given,
Yet at tremendous price;
The Son of God from Heaven,
Became the sacrifice.*

*Forgiveness thus is offered,
Through precious blood outpoured;
The Lamb of God has suffered,
His Name be now adored.*

*Soon shall He come in glory,
And we shall see His face;
Retrace redemption's story,
Recipients of grace.*

Bernie Payne